BOOKS

THE CITY THAT WASN'T



ARCHITECT ROBERT STEPHENS HAS COLLECTED VISIONS OF BOMBAY THAT WERE NEVER REALISED



BOMBAY IMAGINED
An Illustrated History of the Unbuilt City
by Robert Stephens
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In 1869, a municipal engineer came up with an eccentric scheme for a fast-developing Bombay. What if they built an underground railway to ferry commuters to work at Fort in the daytime, and human waste back to the edges of the city at night? Proposed by Hector Tulloch, the dual-objective commuters-and-crap movement system found few supporters.

The Rs 64 lakh scheme became one of the dozens of civic proposals consigned to the scrapheap of unrealised dreams. Now 200 of these have been lovingly collected in a new book, *Bombay Imagined: An Illustrated History of the Unbuilt City*, by architect and civic historian Robert Stephens.

"Imagine if in the 1860s there had been an underground railway, I'm sure it would have been a success," says Stephens. "I really think that would have had the potential to change how the city commutes." But, he concedes laughing, it "would have also been a bit disgusting".

This compendium of 'could-have-beens' traverses possibilities from the 1600s to this century. For a coastal city, a lot of unrealised projects naturally concern the sea, the nearby islands, the eternal questions of land reclamation and sewage treatment. Some highlights from Stephen's findings: an underground hawkers' zone to decongest busy Chowpatty beach (1936), a multi-denominational cremation-cum-burial ground at Matunga (1865), a 'leper island' to isolate the unhealthy offshore (1948). There is even a madcap 1840s plan to convert Elephanta island into a tavern. But these projects and others fizzled out for a number of reasons.

"The most common was budget," says the US-born, Mumbai-based Stephens, who moved here when he was 22. "By and large, people in Bombay's history have tried to solve big problems with really big solutions. And I think the bigger the solution, the less likely it was to be realised." Others failed because of inadequate political support, and some "faced public protest".

A 1670 plan to carve out a city around Bombay Castle was shelved for fear of "further enraging the nature-dependent local populace by felling hundreds of trees", Stephens writes. The Save Aarey and anti-tree cutting campaigns are only the latest examples of citizen opposition. "Someone from the BMC tries to cut down a tree and people go nuts. It's genetic in the city," he says. "I love it! From day one, there has been this love of trees."

That's not the only contemporary resonance. The idea for a coastal road ringing the shoreline was first floated in 1870 but was stymied by charges of "illegal gratification". That project was proposed by the municipal commissioner Arthur Crawford. But city improvement suggestions poured in from everywhere. "The advent of the trained architect and urban planner is actually quite recent," says Stephens. "I really enjoyed including other voices because oftentimes those are actually the voices of logic—common citizens trying to solve problems they see."

The book began seven years ago when Stephens stumbled upon a plan for a 400-acre park at Mahalakshmi dreamt up by Crawford. As he dug deeper, the project threw up dozens of unknown gems. Researched from archives and libraries, through first-person interviews and buttressed with maps, photos and fresh illustrations, *Bombay Imagined* is an affectionate tribute. The ideas encompass both implementable solutions that should have been realised to "just dreams" in a city full of dreamers and visionaries. "Some were never planned to be built," says Stephens. "They were just kind of provocations." ■

–Bhavya Dore



Speculation by ANIKET UMARIA